



Illustration by Mrs. Annita Sobie

How to Craft an Effective Fundraising Letter

WHEN THE WRITTEN WORD IS PRESENTED WITH INTENTION, PRECISION AND FEELING, IT CAN BE A POWERFUL MOTIVATOR. FOLLOWING ARE TIPS I'VE FOUND KEY TO THE SUCCESS OF ANY FUNDRAISING LETTER.

BY MRS. SHULA BRYSKI, THOUSAND OAKS, CALIFORNIA

Start with a Story

Let's face it: most people don't bother reading solicitation letters. If you'd like someone to read yours, the opener has got to catch the reader's interest from the first word in.

Which of the following would you be more likely to continue reading?

A: *We hope this letter finds you well. As we approach the fall season, we will be planning for many important programs to service the community....*

OR

B: *"Zaide, do you know what we learned in school today?" My nine-year-old son was having a discussion with his grandfather....*

Share the Wealth

While it seems obvious to do so, we often forget to articulate the value of our mosad.

Contrast this:

We need the community's financial support to sustain our programs and continue our important work. We hope to expand our existing offerings in the year ahead. With blessings for a sweet new year....

To these:

*Chabad strives to....
Chabad is passionate about filling the community's physical and spiritual needs with....
Chabad's vision is to....
Chabad reached out to 50 teens this year who....
This is important information for someone who isn't familiar with Chabad, as well as serves as an affirmation for the old-timers as to why their continued support is so crucial.*

Relay the Request

The letter may be moving and inspiring but, ultimately, the request must be made in order to actualize its ultimate purpose.
*Please consider an end-of-year gift....
Please partner with us in....
Please support this vital program....*

Give Gratitude

Contrast this:

Enclosed is an envelope so you can support this worthy cause. Please give what you can. Looking forward to staying in touch....

To these:

*It's thanks to your thoughtfulness that we....
Every dollar you contribute is invested in....
We're grateful for your friendship....
When we close with thankfulness, we avoid appearing solely money-focused and present an organization that is genuine, that has not a sense of entitlement but a humble gratefulness for others' kindness and indispensability.*

Keep it Short

These days, people have a limited attention span. You want to pack a punch in few words. While the art of brevity is often difficult to master, the reader is much less likely to read a long, winded letter.

SAMPLE FUNDRAISING LETTER

"Do you know why I keep Shabbat today?" Joshua, an elderly man in our synagogue, asked us one Shabbat afternoon. "Because," he continued,

"although I was raised in a completely non-observant household, I had a third-grade teacher who ignited my spark. I still remember how his eyes shone as he passionately described the special Shabbat foods, prayer services and connection with G-d he experienced each week. My teacher's joy and love for living as a Jew never left me and, years later, when I began my journey of Jewish growth, Shabbat was the first mitzvah I began to keep."

Dear Sam,

Joshua's story of one of millions like it, a tale of the lifelong positive impact created in a Jewish day school classroom. And at the Yourtown Jewish Day School, we, too, set the stage for this story to unfold. Our warm, knowledgeable teachers exude a passion and love for Judaism that shape our students for life. Their personal interest in the well-being of each individual student, along with their superb didactic methods come together to provide our community's children with an optimal Jewish education experience.

At YJDS, no child is turned away for lack of funds. As such, this year we welcomed 15 children into our classrooms free of charge. We do, however, still need to pay our dedicated staff and cover other bills, such as electricity, water and gas. Please partner with us today and enable us to keep our doors open. With your help, we will continue to write the story of many more Joshuas.

On behalf of our students and their families, we thank you in advance for your support.

Rabbi and Mrs. Shluchim

P.S. \$2740 will sponsor a child for one day at YJDS. \$54.80 pays for two days and \$137 sponsors an entire week of a rich YJDS education. Please send your gift in the enclosed envelope today! 📧

NEXT ISSUE:
What to Include in a Thank-You Letter

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